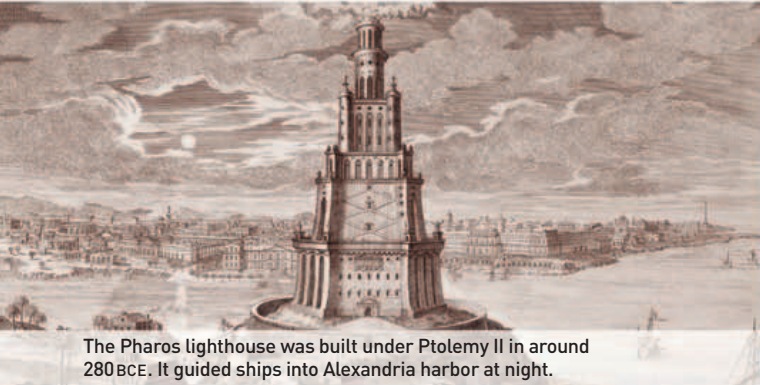




The Pharos lighthouse was built under Ptolemy II in around 280 BCE. It guided ships into Alexandria harbor at night.

IN ITALY, A THIRD WAR broke out between the **Romans and Samnites** in 298 BCE, apparently provoked by Samnite harassment of their neighbors, the Lucanians. Despite two Roman victories in 297 BCE, the Samnites, this time allied with the Gauls, could still field a huge army against the Romans at **Sentinum** in 295 BCE.

275

THE NUMBER OF YEARS THE PTOLEMAIC DYNASTY RULED EGYPT

The equally vast Roman army—at 45,000, the largest they had ever fielded—was threatened with defeat until the Roman consul **Publius Decius Mus** (d. 295 BCE) dedicated himself and the enemy army as sacrificial victims to the gods of the underworld and led a **suicidal charge** that shattered the Samnite line. A string of **Roman successes** followed in 293 and 292 BCE, and two years later the Samnites finally surrendered and their lands were annexed. Roman territory now stretched across the Italian peninsula to the Adriatic Sea.

Demetrius Poliorcetes (c. 337–283 BCE), the son of Antigonos (see 322–301 BCE), was now rebuilding his strength from bases in the Aegean islands and in Cyprus. He was able to exploit the need of **Seleucus**, in Babylon, for allies against the now overmighty **Lysimachus**. In 294 BCE, Demetrius **invaded Macedon**, whose ruler Cassander had died three years before, leaving his two young sons to engage in a **bitter civil war**. Demetrius then attacked Lysimachus's Asian territories, but in 292 BCE he was brought back to Greece by a revolt in Aetolia. By 289 BCE, Demetrius had suppressed the revolt, but he had lost most of his island bases to Ptolemy's Egyptian fleet. He retreated to Asia, and died in 283 BCE, a captive of Seleucus.

Of Alexander's successors, Ptolemy inherited the weakest position. A naval defeat in 306 BCE by Demetrius Poliorcetes confined his ambitions temporarily to Egypt. Yet here he shrewdly chose to exploit the existing mechanisms of power, establishing himself as a pharaoh in the old style and setting up an administration that melded the best of Greek and Egyptian traditions. By 295 BCE, Ptolemy's naval forces had recovered and conquered much of the Aegean. In Egypt, Ptolemy's position was sufficiently secure that, at his death in 283 BCE, aged 84, he passed the kingdom on to his son Ptolemy II Philadelphos (r. 283–245 BCE), the second king of a Ptolemaic dynasty that would rule Egypt until 30 BCE.

“ANOTHER SUCH VICTORY AND WE ARE UNDONE.”

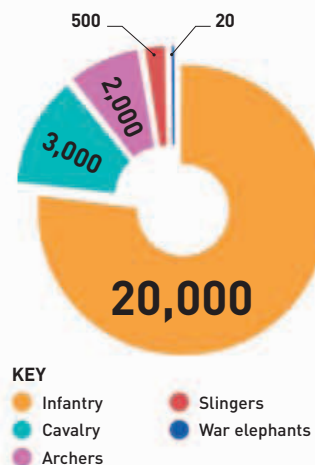
Pyrrhus, king of the Greek state of Epirus, 279 BCE

IN 281 BCE, THE APPEAL by envoys from the southern Italian city of Tarentum for protection against the Romans provided **Pyrrhus**, the king of the Greek state of Epirus, with a perfect excuse for fulfilling his ambitions and intervening there. He arrived with an army more than 25,000 strong, including war elephants. He beat the Romans at the **River Siris** in 280 BCE, but the Roman senate refused to make peace. Pyrrhus vanquished another Roman army at **Asculum** the next year, but his losses were so severe that it seemed more like a defeat. After invading Sicily, Pyrrhus retreated back to **Epirus** in 275 BCE, nursing huge losses in troops and having made no territorial gains.

The defeat and **death of Lysimachus** in 281 BCE in battle



Pyrrhus of Epirus
Despite his many campaigns, when Pyrrhus died he ruled little more than the kingdom he had inherited.



Pyrrhus's army

The army that Pyrrhus took over to Italy included a small number of war elephants, whose presence caused the Roman cavalry to panic and flee.

against Seleucus, and the latter's assassination, soon led to instability on the frontier between the **Seleucid Empire** (now ruled by his son Antiochus II) and the Egyptian ruler **Ptolemy II Philadelphos**. Finally, in 274 BCE the **First Syrian War** broke out between them. The Egyptians emerged victorious, annexing parts of the Syrian coast and southern Anatolia. This position was in part reversed by Egyptian losses in the **Second Syrian War** (260–253 BCE) and then renewed in the **Third Syrian War** (246–241 BCE), which was fought between the Seleucid **Antiochus II** and **Ptolemy III**. These three debilitating wars left the Seleucids particularly vulnerable to the now growing power of **Parthia**.



At the Battle of Mylae, in 260 BCE, Rome defeated the Carthaginian navy.

IN INDIA, the accession of **Ashoka** (c. 294–232 BCE) to the throne in 268 BCE had marked a watershed for the **Mauryan Empire**. On his father Bindusara's death (see 322–301 BCE), Ashoka had to fight a four-year **civil war** with his brothers before he was enthroned. Around eight years later, he launched a campaign against **Kalinga** (modern Orissa), which was so bloody that around 100,000 people are said to have died. So struck with remorse was Ashoka at this slaughter, that he ever after rejected war and promoted the Buddhist concept of **dharma**, meaning mercy or piety. He set up a series of edicts carved in rock throughout the empire—many of them on pillars topped with a lion—promoting his adherence to dharma. Under his patronage the **Third Buddhist Council** met at Pataliputra around 250 BCE, and Ashoka sought to export his ideas abroad, exchanging diplomatic missions with foreign rulers, such as **Antiochus II of Syria** and **Ptolemy II of Egypt**. At his death in 232 BCE, the Mauryan Empire had reached its greatest extent and seemed securely established.

In China, **Zhao Zheng** succeeded his father to the throne of Qin in 246 BCE. From 228 BCE, ably advised by **chancellor Li Si**, Zhao Zheng unleashed a final war of conquest against the remaining **Warring States** (see 370–356 BCE). Zhao and Yan soon fell to his forces, the Qin armies captured Wei and, in 223 BCE, overcame Chu. Only Qi still held out but, in 221 BCE, Zhao Zheng finally annexed it, leaving

